Pushing out the boats

Fiona Wilson REPORTING FROM Okinawa prefecture: With territorial disputes in the East China Sea intensifying, the Japan Coast Guard has had to rapidly evolve to contend with new threats. We drop anchor at Ishigaki Island, where its crew police these vital waters.

With its sugar-cane fields, sun-drenched beaches and clear, subtropical waters, Ishigaki Island could hardly look less like the front line of a conflict. But this small dot in southern Japan lies a little more than 300km from Taiwan and about 170km from the rocky, uninhabited Senkaku Islands (known as Diaoyu by China), which are administered by Tokyo but claimed by both Beijing and Taipei. If the dispute over the islands heats up or China invades Taiwan, sleepy Ishigaki might suddenly find itself uncomfortably close to the action.

For now the island's two faces - a holiday destination and a strategic military base - coexist quite peacefully. Tourists can go snorkelling and sample the local cuisine (its tender beef is a speciality), happily oblivious to the geopolitical storm threatening to break at sea. The urban centre, also called Ishigaki, is Japan's southernmost city; with a population of 49,000, the island is the Yaeyama archipelago's commercial hub. Beyond it, roads lead to farms, beach resorts and popular sunset spots.

As China makes its presence felt in the region, Japan has increased the visibility of its Coast Guard. Hardly a day passes when Chinese Coast Guard vessels don't enter the waters around the Senkaku Islands; in 2022 they sailed within this contiguous zone for a record 336 days, up from 171 in 2017. Japan's IIth Regional Coast Guard, which covers Ishigaki, has more than doubled in size since 2010, rising from 820 personnel to 1,972. In that time, its fleet has grown from 26 ships to 50 and the number of aircraft has risen from II to 15.

Rear Admiral Mitsuaki Nakata is the commander of the Ishigaki Coast Guard Office. What would once have been a quiet posting is now a high-profile role. His office, which has a staff of 45, is a stone's throw from Ishigaki Port, which boasts an impressive line-up of Coast Guard boats. Day and night, patrol vessels rotate in and out of the port, keeping a close eye on what Chinese boats are up to around the disputed islands. "We make sure that we can outnumber them," says Rear Admiral Nakata.

Eight potential texts from MONOCLE

In terms of vessel numbers, the China Coast Guard's fleet far surpasses that of Japan: in 2023 it already had more than twice as many vessels exceeding 1,000 tonnes. This disparity is only expected to grow. With its larger boats and upgraded equipment, China is able to increase its presence in disputed waters, even at long distances from the coast. The Japan Coast Guard can't compete but is hoping for an uplift in its budget for the next financial year from ¥243bn (€1.5bn) in 2023 to $275.9bn (€1.75bn). It is also seeking to add 432 new staff to its current total of nearly 14,700 by 2025 and, in the longer term, boost its number of large patrol vessels from 71 to 90 by 2028.

"And if we don't have enough in Ishigaki, we'll call in others." China's almost permanent presence in the contiguous zone isn't illegal but its vessels now cross over into Japan's territorial waters two or three days a month. "When they do that, we escort them out," Nakata tells MONOCLE. The aim, he says, is to keep things peaceful. "Tensions have increased in this region but no matter what the security situation is, we perform our role, which is to act as the police. We stick to the law and do so calmly. We don't want to provoke a conflict."

The Japan Coast Guard is keen to differentiate its role from that of the Japan Self-Defense Forces (SDF), which are still forbidden by the country's pacifist constitution from military aggression. Coast Guard boats have guns but almost never use them - the exception being an incident in 2001 when four of its vessels clashed with a North Korean spy boat off Kyushu before it was eventually sunk.

The SDF has increased its presence on Ishigaki too. In 2023 the island received its first SDF garrison with 570 personnel. The 47-hectare site in the middle of Ishigaki was the final part of the solution to what the Japan Ministry of Defense identified as a regional security "vacuum". It followed three other SDF garrisons that have been built on the small Okinawan islands of Yonaguni and Miyakojima, and the island of Amami-Oshima in Kagoshima. The new garrison, with its anti-aircraft and missile companies, has received mixed reac-tions. While some locals welcome the boost to the economy, others fear that it will make Ishigaki a target in any future conflict.

Nakata, who has served with the Coast Guard for 38 years, points out that Senkaku isn't Japan's only potential territorial flashpoint. "I'm from Hokkaido," he says. "There the focus is on Russia and the Northern Territories disputed islands claimed by both Moscow and Tokyo]. When I was in Tsushima in Nagasaki prefecture, Korea was the important

factor. Here in Okinawa, it's China. It depends on where you are in Japan but there's always an international dimension to the job."

The Senkaku Islands aren't the only preoccupation of the Ishigaki Coast Guard. It has to deal with everything from maritime rescue missions and natural disasters to medical emergencies and even public education. Recent call-outs have included rescuing campers stranded on a typhoon-stricken beach, saving the crew of a sinking tanker, picking up a stand-up paddleboarder who had drifted to a neighbouring island and dealing with a variety of smuggling, including of gold, drugs and guns. Tipoffs and searches have produced an array of contraband hidden in the vast cruise ships that come into Ishigaki from Taiwan. In the port, it's cleaning day on patrol vessel Tarama. Under the watchful eye of its captain, Yoshitaka Morimoto, its crew is scrubbing and painting the boat, which weighs more than 1,700 tonnes and is almost 100 metres long. Morimoto is on his fourth tour of Okinawa. If he spots anything untoward from the bridge, he informs the regional headquarters in the city of Naha. Most crew members live in dormitories and are sometimes out on patrol for a week. Life in the Coast Guard is peripatetic, with postings lasting only two or three years.

The Ishigaki Coast Guard has a 68-strong air base next to the airport. Established in 1972, its personnel have been making sea rescues and transporting sick people from remote islands to hospitals for more than 50 years. Its immaculate hangar looks straight onto Mount Omoto, Okinawa's highest mountain. Diving suits hang on a rack on one side; two modified Beech 350 Super King Air planes sit alongside one of two Agusta AW139 helicopters. This is also the base of the Coast Guard's rescue technicians, the specialists who hang off helicopters in the roughest of seas. They're an elite group (there are only 90 in Japan), selected from the ranks of divers and trained for another nine months.

The Agusta helicopter is a bruiser, capable of carrying nearly 270kg on an 80-metre cable. "It's easy to fly," says chief pilot Tadakiyo Narita, who has nearly 30 years of experience behind him. "It can operate in difficult conditions, even right before or after a typhoon when most planes can't fly." A I,800-watt searchlight, which is so bright that its use when flying at low altitude over land is forbidden, is a crucial tool on rescue missions, while loudspeakers beneath it are used to make announcements, such as calls to evacuate. Pilots are sometimes tasked with bringing patients from small islands into Yaeyama hospital, the region's largest medical facility, in Ishigaki. The planes can cover great distances during search-and-rescue operations, locate the scene and drop parachute lights as

markers for the teams that follow. On regular patrols, pilots are on the lookout for illegal fishing boats; if any are found, they pass on information to patrol vessels that then move the boats on.

Nakata is now too high-ranking to head out on a patrol ship but it's something that he misses. After nearly 40 years, he would still recommend a career in the Coast Guard. "Moving from place to place can be hard on families but it has its perks," he says. "You get to experience things that you would never have otherwise. There is a lot to learn and be proud of in this job."

Second wind

Daniel Meyerowiz REPORTING FROM Copenhagen: As cargo freighters begin exploring the possibility of traversing the oceans with the help of hi-tech sails, smaller vintage fleets are showing them the way.

If it takes a long time to turn a cargo ship around, try getting the entire shipping industry to change course - to a cleaner future. Having spent 200 years burning the dirtiest combustibles, some ship owners are discovering that the most promising technology for their industry is one abandoned years ago: the abundant, free fuel called wind. That's why cargo decks are sprouting all manner of breeze catchers, each an ungainly prototype, competing to see which is best at augmenting grubby engine power with wind-assisted propulsion.

While these eye-catching experiments make headlines and win investment, a smaller fleet of wind-powered pioneers is sometimes overlooked. These heritage wooden schooners and newly designed sailing ships have formed a loose global alliance that's attracting venture capital and enjoying a told-you-so moment. The maritime industry has agreed to quit carbon by 2050 but this vintage fleet is proving that, for some cargo, emissions-free shipping is available now. It might seem that the giant cargo carriers revisiting sail power and their tiny brethren who never deserted tides and trade winds sit in opposite camps. But differences aside, their combined efforts are shaking up an industry that has long been resistant to change.

It took the hottest summer in history for the UN's International Maritime Organization (IMO) to finally commit to quitting carbon "by or around 2050". While the finish line remains maddeningly vague, the starting gun has fired. Few sounds are sweeter to John Cooper, veteran of both McLaren Formula I and the Americas Cup. Now CEO of maritime innovator BAR Technologies, he's confident that ocean carriers will be transformed by sail power. Or at least, by the sail his team is designing: Windwings.

These giant steel and glass-composite contraptions can be raised to provide propulsion, lowered in a storm and manoeuvred according to the direction of the wind. The Pyxis Ocean, a bulk carrier, was the first ship retrofitted with this new technology. Owned by Mitsubishi Corporation and chartered by agricultural powerhouse Cargill, the Pyxis

Eight potential texts from MONOCLE

Ocean emerged from its dry dock in Shanghai with two huge Windwings lashed to its deck. Though they might not be pretty, these sails do look like they mean business.

We catch up with Cooper during his early morning drive to BAR's Portsmouth HQ. He's cautious of making too many promises about Windwings' performance.

Don't expect headlines, he says, like: "Technology provider stuns the world with their own figures." What he does claim, however, is that his sails "have substantially more thrust than anybody out there".

The Pyxis Ocean has already completed its first voyages - from China to Singapore, then on to Brazil and Poland - with Cooper commissioning independent experts to publicly report on its emission reductions. "No other wind-propulsion company has ever done that," he says. "And I'll tell you why: because they're not making the savings that they claim. We will be dominant in this market."

But market domination won't come without a fight. Along with competing rigid-wing designs entering the fray, a dizzying variety of novel wind-propulsion ideas are taking shape. While cleaner fuels will also contribute to greener sailing, the surest way to reach the IMO target - and minimise looming carbon taxes - is to find the best wind solution. As a result, a parade of varied sails is dotting the horizon.

Tyre-maker Michelin is developing - what else? - inflatable sails. A couple of its Wing Sail Mobility models already help to propel the 12,000-tonne carrier MN Pelican between the UK and Spain. Modelled after aircraft wings, the retractable sails allow for navigation in ports and under bridges, and are in sea trials to assess savings. Not to be outdone, French designer Airseas looked to kite surfing for inspiration. It wants to help pull cargo ships by using flying sails, which would be attached with cables to the bow. Transatlantic tests are under way.

Meanwhile, Norway's Hurtigruten is designing an eco cruise ship. Sketches show a classic floating hotel: bulging prow, gleaming decks and three massive smokestacks amidships. But instead of smoke pouring from the chimneys, giant sails pop out, covered in solar panels.

Whichever design wins out, the reward might be substantial. Out of about 60,000 carriers worldwide, few are currently using wind-assisted propulsion. But according to non-profit International Windship Association, that number could skyrocket to one in every six ships

by this decade's end. Yet even if this very optimistic forecast is achieved, it will still be a far cry from - and 20 long years until - the IMO's emissions target is met. This is where the smaller wooden ships are making a mark as successful examples of zero-carbon mobility that the mainstream industry has pledged to meet.

The same week that the Pyxis Ocean set off for Europe, another sail-powered pioneer, the Tres Hombres, docked in Copenhagen. The ship's arrival stopped traffic as, one after another, the city's famous bridges opened to let it pass. Like the Pyxis, this ship is a remarkable sight, having crossed the Atlantic on a breeze, laden with food bound for Europe. But that's where the similarities end. While the huge Pyxis is cautiously attempting its first deliveries under sail, the smaller Tres Hombres has completed hundreds. And though BAR's experimental wings do reduce fuel use, Tres Hombres makes the 9,000km trip without a fuel tank. After all, it's an 80-year-old wooden boat carrying cargo the traditional way: by wind alone.

The Tres Hombres is not the only boat demonstrating how solutions from an earlier maritime age can benefit our present one. From schooner Apollonia navigating the Hudson River in New York to Sail Cargo London plying the Thames, and from France to Fiji, a growing number of entrepreneurs are putting sail heritage back to work.

It's a rich history for Netherlands-based Fairtransport. Now in its 17th year, the company is profitable and expanding at pace. "At the beginning, we were laughed at," says CEO Sabine Fox. "Now everyone is trying to copy us." And it's easy to see why. With demand increasing for climate-friendly ways to convey cargo and passengers, Fairtransport has seen its fortunes rise, even during the pandemic, various global conflicts and other ill winds. Though Fox grew up near the sea, she never expected to make it her future, training instead for a career in law. By chance, her first job was at Rostock’s Hanse Sail maritime festival. She hasn’t looked back since. At another harbour fair, she picked up a flyer from three friends – the “tres hombres” of their flagship’s name – seeking partners to find a ship and revive sailed cargo.

The boat that they found was a wrecked Second World War-era German minesweeper, destined for the scrap heap. Instead, they gave it a new lease of life as a champion of zero-carbon trade. Starting with just one vessel, Fairtransport is now a shipping agent for three more. Imports include organic cocoa, coffee, rum and other delicacies from the Americas. With a crew of 15, Tres Hombres also transports salt from France, olive oil from Portugal,

honey from Spain and wine from all three. “Our customers have grown with us,” says Fox, mentioning several, such as Switzerland’s Atinkana Kaffee and Chocolatemakers from the Netherlands. “As they get bigger, we’re able to put more cargo on more ships, including new ones we’re developing.”

Asked about the new vessels and clients, Sabine demurs. “I am a little hesitant to name them because so many new shippers want our customers,” she says. “Sail cargo is definitely growing. There’s enough for everybody if we’re not all importing the same goods to the same people.” However, she is able to reveal that Fairtransport is expanding into Sweden and increasing deliveries to Denmark.

And it’s here in Copenhagen that wine merchants Rosforth & Rosforth welcomed the Tres Hombres for its third visit this year. The ship docked just past Knippelsbro bridge, which is in the heart of the Danish capital. As masts creaked and canvas stirred, the snug brigantine was thronged by locals, snapping selfies with this vision from their city’s past. Some passers-by even volunteered to help unload its 20,000 bottles of Loire Valley vintages. The boxes were then stacked on freight bicycles, which ferried them off to the city’s restaurants.

As customer demand grows, the company is helping to fill the holds of similar ships in France and Germany. Those boats are also busy with their own clients. As word spreads about truly climate-friendly transport, all sorts of requests flow in. One is from artist Olafur Eliasson’s studio in Berlin, reserving space for artwork bound for Manhattan.

While these green journeys need no fuel, they do require plenty of elbow grease. To provide it, the ships welcome passengers who pay for the privilege of being trainees and stevedores while travelling the world carbon-free. Some of these paying guests find ship life so appealing that they stay on as paid crew, with one even becoming captain. Those who sail the Tres Hombres all the way to Martinique might end up doing the frog kick, swimming with barrels of rum from tropical beaches to the side of the ship. These long winter journeys are so popular, berths sell out more than a year in advance.

For those who might prefer getting their Caribbean liquor faster, Fox suggests a visit to the German Rum Festival. At this annual Berlin conclave, the world’s finest spirits are blind-tested by experts. “There has been no year we entered when Tres Hombres rum did not win a medal,” says Fox. “Last time, it was a gold and two bronzes.” The secret? Months spent under sail. Deep in the holds of traditional ships, rum inside wooden barrels

gently moves with the waves, deepening, maturing and interacting with tannins in the oak staves.

These vintage rum runners might soon be joined by a modern steel incarnation of the classic clipper ship, launched by France's TransOceanic Wind Transport (TOWT). "What we're creating here is a new generation of 21st-century vessels, inspired by the heritage of sail propulsion," says ceo Guillaume Le Grand.

Seeing the advantages of both a zero-carbon fleet and mainstream carriers, TOWT hopes to create a niche somewhere in between. "We're cherry-picking technologies from all the sectors: fishing, regatta, cargo," says Le Grand. "Our boats, which are 90 per cent sail-powered, are using carbon masts and will be the sons and daughters of the old ships."

Anemos – which is Greek for "wind" – will be the first TOWT ship, one of two set to launch in 2024. Aiming for a maiden voyage in April, Anemos is designed to have more freight capacity and passenger berths than the Tres Hombres, but only half the crew. TOWT also hopes for shorter crossing times thanks to mechanised sails. "We've got tremendous commercial traction at the moment," says Le Grand, pointing to their ability to negotiate long-term contracts. "We're telling customers that one hop across the Atlantic for greenwashing PR is not what we do. If you want to load your cargo on board, you'll have to sign a contract that commits you to several crossings." So far, TOWT has firm cargo commitments from wine and spirits seller Pernod Ricard and other leading French brands.

This is still a period of experimentation, development and investment for both sectors: the sail-only fleet and its giant cargo cousins. And there are opportunities for co-operation. One example is the crucial last mile of carbon-free delivery. Many mega-freighters can only squeeze into huge container terminals. Agile smaller craft can meet them dockside, cross-load cargo, then navigate it to downtown Hamburg, Amsterdam, London and countless other harbours.

Wind-assisted propulsion might also lead these different fleets to sail the same routes. Standard cargo ships, using engine power alone, could sometimes ignore breezes when mapping a journey. But as they adopt hi-tech sails to reduce emissions, that calculus will change. According to Cooper, it might even prove economical for sail-assisted carriers to stop going back and forth across the Atlantic. Instead, it could be smarter to sail continuously around the globe, following the trade winds. In that scenario, the heritage

cargo fleet – along with racing teams and other open-ocean mariners – will have valuable experience to share about optimising routes and logistics for wind. So like sharks and remora fish, the massive cargo carriers and small sailing vessels might find ways to assist each other as maritime commerce goes green.

But what has been most important to both fleets is that vintage ships are proving themselves powerful ambassadors for wind-powered transport. They're building global awareness and a loyal customer base, which is willing to pay the sometimes higher cost of transitioning to clean ocean shipping.

Whether the two sectors choose to compete, co-operate or ignore each other, one thing is clearly on the horizon: more sails. Lots of them – steel ones bolted to giant carriers and canvas flapping on ships such as the Tres Hombres, returning the richness of slow-sailed coffee, cocoa and rum to Denmark's capital.

But for Danes, the most exciting taste these ships are delivering might be something else. By reviving dockside flavours and accents, clamour and commerce, visitors such as the Tres Hombres are also bringing back the original meaning of the name Copenhagen: Merchants' Harbour.

Eight potential texts from MONOCLE

Live and learn

Julia Webster Ayuso REPORTING FROM Venice: An architecture in the City of Bridges aims to arm the next generation of urbanists and designers with hands-on skills needed to combat climate change. We meet those who are spearheading their education.

In a former cotton mill in the southwest corner of Venice, a group of international students has gathered in a classroom for a special guest lecture called Managing Waters. Projected onto a white screen at the front of the room, a slide reads: "The protection of Venice and its lagoon against flooding." Francesco Musco, a professor of urban planning and deputy dean of research at the Istituto Universitario di Architettura di Venezia (IUAV), is keeping an eye on things through the classroom door's round windows.

Musco has just completed a research project on the efficacy of Venice's flood barriers, the Modulo Sperimentale Elettromeccanico (Mose), which began operating in the lagoon in 2020 to ward off tidal surges. Off the back of these studies, he has called on colleagues in various disciplines to come and talk to his students. "The master's programme in urban planning and transition is about making our cities more resilient to climate change," he says, while walking Monocle through the halls of the old industrial building (the Sedi Cotonificio was renovated into classrooms, studios and lecture halls by celebrated mid-century architect Gino Valle when the university expanded in the 1990s).

It's an educational ambition that's seeing IUAV, which was founded in 1926 as Italy's second public architecture school after Rome's Scuola Superiore di Architettura, emerge as an appealing place for architects from across the globe to continue their studies. The university introduced Italy's first master's degree in urban planning in 1970 and today it continues to be a hub of innovation, attracting students who are keen to learn in - and from - a city at the forefront of climate change, mass tourism and cultural conservation.

At the forefront of this concept of learning from the city is Valeria Tatano. As a professor of architectural technology at IUAV, she is keen to get her students out into the city as much as possible. "Studying at your desk and at the library is all very well but in Venice there is a lesson to be learnt at every street corner," she says. The previous week, she took a class to the Procuratie Vecchie in St Mark's Square, a residence for public prosecutors built in the 1500s and recently restored by architect David Chipperfield. A short walk from the building, a small barrier has been erected around the square's basilica to protect

the 1,000-year-old church from moderate floods (at present the square finds itself under water some 60 times a year). "I can explain a million times how or why something is done but when students are able to see, touch, take pictures - then they have many more questions," she says.

Seeing such work first hand is critical for architecture students who are moving into a professional world where environmentally minded approaches are key to project briefs. Built on a marshland in the centre of the lagoon, Venice has always had to find a balance between the urban and natural worlds. And it is a balance that is only becoming more important: since 2020 the Mose barriers have been raised 50 times, with some scientists predicting that, despite their effectiveness, the city could be under water in less than a century. Add to this the increased pressure on architects to design buildings that are in tune with the environment and it's understandable why living and studying in Venice, where a changing climate is so visible, is increasingly appealing. Back on campus, Musco says that this is a key quality of the city that is attracting urban-minded architectural students. "Venice's peculiarities make it very representative of many coastal cities."

But it's not just environmental problems that are strengthening IUAV’s educational offering; it's the fact that every aspect of delivering a building poses a challenge in the city, from access to supply chains to connectivity beyond its islands. Here, buildings are battling sinking foundations (Venice is constructed on timber piles pushed into the loose mud and clay of the lagoon), while electricity, water and gas pipelines need to cross bridges and be hidden beneath pavements. Such topics are currently being unpacked in one of IUAV's international architecture master's programmes, where students from countries as varied as Ecuador, the US and Russia are working in groups to design an exhibition space in Ca' Zenobio degli Armeni, a baroque palazzo. One of the challenges that students are being pushed to consider is how, in order to build the structure, construction materials would be transported through the canals. "It might seem obvious but studying in Venice is incredibly valuable," says Michel Carlana, who studied architecture at IUAV and now teaches here, while also running his Treviso-based architecture practice. Bruno Tello Fernández, an architecture master's student from Seville agrees. "Venice is one of the few examples of this particular way of life," he says, while working on his design for the exhibition space. "Studying here helps you see how people adapt to different types of architecture [and ways of building)."

Significantly, and important to IUAV’s plans, is the fact that the university brings urban planning and architecture together with courses in design, fashion and theatre. In the corridors of Sedi Cotonificio, as well as in the narrow streets that connect to the main university building in Sedi dei Tolentini (with an entrance designed by one of IUAV's most celebrated former directors, Carlo Scarpa), the university's 4,000-odd students can be seen carrying everything from rolls of sketches to architectural models and coat hangers. Tatano, who like most professors was also a student here, says that this holistic, design-oriented approach gives a richness to the university's courses. "Being a small university means that we're all constantly on top of each other," she says. "But it means that someone designing a building is shoulder to shoulder with someone designing a skirt."

In addition to learning from the city’s problems, IUAV is also seeking ways to solve them. High rents mean that most students can’t afford to live on the islands of Venice and must commute from the mainland but the ancient city is also in desperate need of newcomers: it has lost 120,000 residents since the early 1950s. Recognising that for the city to continue to be an educational tool it also needs to be a place where people want to live, the university is planning to grow in an attempt to help repopulate Venice’s main islands. A project called Venezia Città Campus has been established in collaboration with city hall and Venice’s other public university, Ca’ Foscari, which will expand teaching space and student accommodation to welcome an additional 60,000 students in the next 10 years.

“We need to show ourselves to the world not just as a mythical place to visit but also as a tangible possibility for residency and work,” said Venice mayor Luigi Brugnaro at an event presenting the project in early 2023. “Venice anticipates the problems that affect the entire country and it’s important to find solutions, like we did with Mose.” By putting its students in front of such problems, and by presenting its own ways forward by contributing to projects such as Venezia Città Campus, IUAV will play a leading role in building the Venice of the future. Other cities around the world will be watching closely.

Face value

Zoe Suen REPORTING FROM South Korea: Exacting beauty standards and savvy consumers have driven South Korean brands to innovate when it comes to clean ingredients and smart branding. Here's how K-beauty is out to dominate at home and abroad.

South Korean city dwellers are known for dressing extremely well and being groomed to perfection. This pursuit of flawless looks has given rise to a $12.6bn (EII.9bn) domestic beauty industry - known as K-beauty - that is often years ahead of international competitors when it comes to trends, product development and ingredient research. "What you get here are hyper-educated consumers and every industry is only as competitive as its consumers demand it to be," says Alicia Yoon, the Korean-US founder of clean beauty brand Peach & Lily. "Alongside K-pop and K-dramas, K-beauty has become one of the most important pillars of the Korean wave," says Jamie Kim, head of the global marketing division at Amorepacific, a Seoul-based beauty conglomerate. She is referring to hallyu, a cultural phenomenon and soft-power triumph that has seen bands such as BIS and TV shows including Squid Game capture the world's attention.

Amorepacific's star line-up includes businesses in every sector of the market, from high-end player Sulwhasoo to its accessible, high-street equivalent Innisfree and mid-market Laneige, which is said to sell one of its famous Lip Sleeping Masks every three seconds. In addition to Amorepacific, the local market also has powerful beauty players such as LG H&H, the household and healthcare arm of the electronics multinational with a market cap of $7.4bn (€7bn), and top manufacturers Kolmar, Cosmax and Cosmecca.

Easy access to manufacturing has also created opportunities for the next generation of entrepreneurial South Koreans, with many independent names cropping up in recent years on online marketplaces such as Kakao and Olive Young. "Everyone in South Korea who loves beauty is able to make their own products and launch a brand," says Daye Choi, co-founder of cosmetics brand Hince, who is in the process of launching a new body and hair-care business. K-beauty businesses are eager to claim their status as market pioneers, capitalising on the interest in their nation's beauty culture. Their hero products, from moisturising sunscreens and snail serums to sheet masks, are no longer reserved for South Koreans or beauty connoisseurs committed to making an annual trip to Seoul. These items have infiltrated the global mainstream and the city's beauty entrepreneurs are becoming

ambitious with their international expansion plans, challenging their European counterparts which, until recently, monopolised the beauty industry. For the first time last year, exports of South Korean beauty products to Japan surpassed those from France, contributing to an export market for beauty products that is worth $9.2bn (€8.7bn), according to South Korea's Ministry of Food and Drug Safety.

South Korea's intimate relationship with beauty can be traced back to gwan-sang, an ancient concept whereby your fortune is laid bare on your face. But more recent political and economic factors have also helped shape the nation's modern beauty standards. Stanford scholar So-Rim Lee looks to the Korean War and the proliferation of reconstructive surgery for the wounded as a key moment that reframed the national mindset, encouraging South Koreans to view the face, the body and consequently their destiny as something that could always be improved. Then high levels of unemployment, caused in part by the 1997 Asian Financial Crisis, led to the normalisation of plastic surgery used to increase people's chances of finding a job.

In 2018, job-search website Saramin revealed that six out of 10 HR managers agreed that a candidate's physical appearance affected their prospects - hence why complex beauty routines, advanced ingredients and often surgery are now considered commonplace, particularly in Seoul. "Constantly curious about new ingredients, products and brands, South Korean choppers are fluent in the language of beauty," says Zoe Heo of Seoul-based creative consultancy Lippincott. Shoppers here often use ingredient-tracking apps and in-depth reviews to inform their purchases, judging products on a scorecard and taking into account factors such as texture, packaging, value for money and, increasingly, sustainability.

With the bar set so high, beauty brands of all sizes invest heavily in innovation. Research, and the development of fresh. formulas and packaging solutions, are top of the agenda, with recent launches including battery-free microcurrent devices that stimulate facial muscles, compostable sheet face masks made from corn starch and ingredients such as Centella asiatica (a herb that boasts a host of anti-oxidative and soothing properties).

"The biggest trait of the South Korean beauty market is that it is very sensitive o changing trends," says Choi. "It might sound ridiculous but a 10-year-long shift in the global beauty market takes only two to three years here." For this reason, K-beauty formulas, suppliers and ingredients are now dispersed throughout global supply chains; it is a sphere of

influence that isn't always apparent. Cosmax, which calls itself one of the world's leading health and beauty manufacturers, is a case in point: according to the company, a quarter of the world's population uses its products and 15 out of 20 of the top companies in the global beauty market count it as a partner. In 2021 the business also launched Cosmax Plus, a one-stop online service to help prospective entrepreneurs develop everything from formulas and packaging to branding and design.

This commitment to innovation is helping South Korean beauty businesses lead the way in clean beauty. Their new-age, environmentally friendly ingredients packaging are delivering efficient results but also offering sustainable solutions for the broader beauty industry. The market for "inner beauty" – positioned at the intersection of K-beauty and wellness (including products such as drinkable collagen supplements) - is also creating room for further growth and could exceed 25trn won (€18bn) by 2030, according to the Korea Health Supplements Association. It's why Amorepacific has been investing in the sector by way of its supplement brand Vital Beautie and its body care brand Longtake, known for using upcycled oak to create its signature woody fragrances. The group acquired US clean-beauty brand Tata Harper in 2022 for 168bn won (€118m) - another sign of South Korean beauty players' global ambition. Elsewhere, there's potential in less-crowded categories such as hair and nail care, and fragrances, where independent brands including Beauty of Joseon and RomEnd are experiencing rapid growth. "As opposed to large corporations that rely on celebrity endorsements to promote their products, we're seeing more smaller companies like ours gaining market share by focusing on branding," says Hae-young Cha, who founded the fragrance and body-care brand Nonfiction.

It seeks to enhance everyday rituals through subtle, handsomely packaged unisex scents and creams. In 2022, sales hit $40m (€37.9m), a 30 per cent boost compared to the previous year. The young business also made its official foray into European retail with a pop-up shop in Paris. "Customers appreciate brands that invest in their packaging and logos because they often perceive this as a sign of overall trust and quality," says Cha, who believes that Nonfiction's visuals and storytelling will resonate with customers abroad, as well as South Koreans.

Expanding globally will bring its own set of challenges for South Korea's beauty businesses - building a localised marketing infrastructure is no small feat, notes Peach & Lily's Alicia Yoon. But these fast-paced businesses see this as an opportunity to open a cross-cultural dialogue and collaborate with new talent on localisation and creative

strategies. While doing so, they're helping to diversify a market that, to date, has been dominated by a handful of European giants, low-cost manufacturing and homogenous design. "With this approach, South Korean brands will be able to compete alongside the biggest global brands," says Cha. "The calibre of our talent will make all the difference."

Eight potential texts from MONOCLE

Hope couture

Jack Simpson REPORTING FROM London: Disruptive fashion star-up Vollebak utilises highly durable, technologically advanced materials to make clothes that will dress many generations to come. And the brand’s low-waste, future-proof mission is winning it some stellar champions and investors.

"Bjarke [Ingels] and I laugh about how people use paint," says Nick Tidball, co-founder of London-based Vollebak, a fashion start-up specialising in new-age materials. It's easy to miss the joke if you're not part of Vollebak's fast-growing innovation team but for Tidball and Ingels (architect and friend of Vollebak), the notion of coating concrete or cotton in oil-based colouring rather than producing a better raw material is laughable. This attitude highlights Vollebak's commitment to producing a new generation of low-waste materials and establishes the label as both an innovator and an outlier.

Launched in 2015 by twin brothers Steve and Nick Tidball, Vollebak quickly built a reputation as an industry rule-breaker, repurposing a vast range of materials including spaceship interiors, bulletproof vests, algae and carbon nano-particles) into familiar wardrobe staples such as chore jackets, waterproof vests and hoodies. "The style is industrial workwear fit for any planet," says Nick of the brand's ambition to design garments made to last for hundreds of years and survive any conditions. It's a novel concept for fashion, challenging the industry's obsession with renewal and encouraging its stakeholders to set new manufacturing standards.

MONOCLE meets the Vollebak team at its King's Cross office, a sprawling, brutalist space filled with whiteboards and prototype jackets dangling from the rafters. It's a cross between a technology lab and a fashion studio, with an eccentricity in the air that's indicative of the Tidball twins' varied inspirations. "We admire people seeking to change industries," says Nick, referring to heroes-turned-confidants such as Ingels, urban designer Neri Oxman and chef René Redzepi of Copenhagen restaurant Noma. The twins also look outside the fashion industry when making new hires - a key part of building a future-proof team. "There are certain skill sets you need in fashion: two thirds of your team need to the industry inside out and the rest need to believe in what you're doing but have no experience of the sector," says Nick, a former architect who came into fashion with an open mind about what could constitute a luxury material. "If your journey isn't typical, you need people who appreciate your motivations and have the same goals."

Eight potential texts from MONOCLE

One of the Tidballs' recent goals was to engineer a jacket built to survive on Mars, using ballistic nylon, typically the base of flak jackets. This sceptical reporter would assume that the market for such an item is nonexistent, yet the team at Vollebak have been able to attract clients, including filmmaker Christopher Nolan, who share the same spirit of adventure. They might not be travelling to Mars any time soon but are drawn to the concept of purchasing a garment that has been designed to last and not end up in landfill. "There are millions of people who want to buy into something that will outlive them," says Nick, optimistic about the scale that these indestructible, zero-waste products will soon achieve.

Building a community of fellow adventurers and futurists is integral to furthering Vollebak's mission. The firm isn't aiming to only speak to the fashion-conscious but to all those willing to share a vision of what it calls "Fourth Age clothing": garments that leave a positive impact on the environment. Adherents include powerful investors - The Alpina Gstaad's Nachson Mimran and Airbnb co-founder Joe Gebbia - as well as discerning luxury clients willing to bet on the label's early-stage experiments. Some Vollebak products have gone to market before the Tidballs were able to determine a material's full potential, with customers becoming field testers and even sharing useful research with the brand. One loyal client recently introduced the team to a new type of aerogel - a material most commonly found inside rockets and spacesuits and now used by Vollebak in foam form to create waterproof jackets. The new Martian Aerogel jacket for instance, weighs a mere 700g and can still keep your core temperature stable at minus 20C.

Elsewhere, materials such as Dyneema, usually spun into anchor ropes on icebreakers, is woven into hoodies to increase their lifespans. The result is the aptly named Indestructible Hoodie, which might be a mere Imm thick but can survive a 75km/h fall and drag on concrete. This might all sound a little extreme but the idea is to address climate change head-on - with products guaranteed to leave no trace behind - or perhaps to prepare ahead for the apocalypse.

Vollebak now has access to numerous materials but the challenge of turning them into wearable products remains. "It doesn't matter what you're drawing, someone has to build it," says Nick of the need to find mills and factories that have the patience for these complex production cycles.

The business is not yet in a position to build its own factory but has managed to establish a number of trusted partnerships with European manufacturers, including a factory on the outskirts of Florence that specialises in making clothing for the Italian military.

For now, many of these material innovations might be confined within Vollebak's London studios - and the wardrobes of a handful of forward-thinking clients - yet the Tidball twins are convinced that a shift is happening on a larger scale. An increased demand for collaboration is fuelling their optimism. Colour-dye company Colorifix, for example, recently spotted the opportunity to revolutionise the dyeing industry with sustainable materials, and turned to Vollebak to help dye a range of T-shirts using genetically engineered indigo-plant DNA. "The world has to experience something new before it decides its old ways are no longer good enough," says Nick. "More and more brands are looking at how we dye our clothes, the materials we use and how artificial intelligence can work out the most efficient way of growing hemp or cotton."

There's still a long road ahead until any of these novelties infiltrate the mainstream - Nick views this as "a 40-year project". But Vollebak is willing to go on the journey, keeping its eyes on the prize and enjoying the experiment along the way.

Outward shift (Text A – Ho Chi Minh City, full length)

James Chambers REPORTING FROM Ho Chi Minh City: Vietnam's rapidly growing economy is becoming increasingly appealing to foreign investors, who are tempted by the dynamism of the country's emerging middle class. Here, we explore the city at the heart of this transformation.

It's morning in Ho Chi Minh City and motorcycles swarm the roads as office workers fill the pavements, drinking hot coffee in the sweltering heat. Amid the everyday mayhem, the first sign that something new is afoot appears in fetching cyan blue. In early 2023 a fleet of electric cabs owned by Vinfast arrived in the country's commercial centre. For the owner of the Vietnamese auto-maker, starting a taxi company was a shortcut to getting these vehicles on the road in a country that has historically had low levels of car ownership.

Vietnam's communist government opened the nation to private enterprise in the late 1980s and, after several false dawns, a middle class is at last emerging. Ho Chi Minh City is the southern gateway to this rapidly growing country of about 100 million people: skyscrapers are rising above the shophouses; two-bedroom flats are selling at New York-style prices and Starbucks has established a presence throughout the city. Michelin recently handed out its first stars to restaurants here and the French, who inspired bánh mì baguettes in the colonial era, continue to influence food retail. Though business has been bumpier than expected in the past year, one of Southeast Asia's most enterprising cities is poised for a bumper 2024 and beyond.

Australian entrepreneur Darren Chew has had a front-row seat to Ho Chi Minh City's transformation. Chew, who originally landed here as a tourist on his way to Europe, co-founded furniture business District Eight in 2010. "When we started out, there wasn't a very big local market," he says, sitting on a couch inside his company's maiden showroom. The downtown shop opened in 2022 as a pop-up; a second, larger showroom, studio and event space will open soon. "We are leaning into the Vietnam thing a little more," adds Chew, who oversaw District Eight's debut at Salone del Mobile in 2023.

The business is named after the location of its original factory (Ho Chi Minh City is divided into 24 mostly numbered districts). That first building was turned into a school by the local government; the company's second factory became a residential development.

Chew must now drive for an hour to a third site in neighbouring Long An province. The journey takes him past a giant Taiwanese-owned factory that produces footwear for Nike and Adidas. Ho Chi Minh City's largest employer, Pouyen, has laid off thousands of staff this year in response to sluggish international demand.

Chew, meanwhile, has been busy adding space to meet a backlog of US orders. Once complete, District Eight's third factory will enable the company to double its turnover by the end of 2024.

"Vietnam is a well-established manufacturing hub but the products are usually only made here, not designed here," says Chew, who wants private-label furniture to generate half of his company's revenue. During MONOCLE's visit, Chinese furniture distributors who saw District Eight at Salone del Mobile and are interested in opening a Shanghai showroom are in Long An. This direction of travel from Vietnam to China - particularly at a time when the business news is full of stories about low-cost manufacturing moving the other way - suggests that Vietnam can be more than a substitute supply chain or a source of cheap labour. Indeed, the country is expected to become a top-10 economy by the end of the decade.

Indochina Capital made its name building Vietnam's top luxury resorts. These days the property investor, which is backed by Japanese construction giant Kajima, is developing two businesses: a hotel brand targeting 70 million domestic travellers and modern factories for European manufacturers with sustainability mandates. "Vietnam needs to define itself" says Michael Piro, the firm's COO and co-founder and CEO of Wink Hotels. "Ho Chi Minh City is at an inflection point, somewhere between frontier and big city."

Foreign capital and talent has played a pivotal role in building the new Vietnam. Overseas Vietnamese are also returning to their parents' homeland, bringing international standards, as well as an eye for design and creature comforts, from pizza to professional sports. But the need to import talent from abroad is declining across industries as a well-educated and hungry domestic workforce rises to the top.

"Many Vietnamese who have studied in other countries are coming home," says Chris Freund, founder of Mekong Capital, from his office in District One, where the company mostly employs local staff. Freund was an early private equity investor in Vietnam. His firm started out in low-cost manufacturing for export, before it switched to the consumer segment and struck gold with an electronics retailer. Its latest fund is betting on consumer

finance and a biotechnology start-up founded by Vietnamese scientists with international degrees. "The market opportunity is great and people here are very open to foreign investment," he says, looking out at the half-completed towers that make up the city's skyline.

Southeast Asia's largest steelworks is a two-hour drive east of downtown Ho Chi Minh City, close to Phu My's deep-water river port. Inside vast factory buildings, coiled sheets of Hoa Sen's prime hot-dipped galvanised steel await shipment to Antwerp and Leixes in Portugal. Factory bosses expect to be operating at close to capacity by April 2024, a year after production hit bottom. Vietnam's economy came roaring out of the coronavirus restrictions in 2022, posting 8 per cent growth, before stumbling this year as a result of the global downturn and a domestic political scandal.

"It's a bump in the road," says Tammy Le, deputy chair of Hoa Sen Investments, during a tour. Le's father founded Hoa Sen in 2001. The publicly listed steel company recently ventured into home improvement, opening more than 100 shops selling toilets and tiles. "There's so much happening here," says Le, who was educated in the US and returned home not long after Vietnam's first McDonald's opened in 2014. The 28-year-old joined her father earlier this year to lead the company's diversification into various industries, including healthcare, student accommodation and entertainment.

Export volumes might go up and down from one quarter to the next but few business leaders here appear to be basing their long-term decisions on factors such as the number of smartphone units leaving Samsung's factory outside the capital, Hanoi. Foreign direct investment into Vietnam has continued to climb throughout the downturn and chambers of commerce are having to hire more staff to handle enquiries from their home markets, bolstered by the geopolitical trade winds blowing manufacturing away from China.

Thai company Central employs about 15,000 people in Vietnam, where it is the leader in hypermarkets. Olivier Langlet joined the company as a country CEO from German multinational retail corporation Metro at the height of the pandemic. "We want to double our number of malls to a minimum of 600," as he outlines plans to invest $I.45bn (€I.3bn) over the next four years. As he shows MONOCLE around one of Central's Go! hypermarkets, he speaks excitedly about the market penetration of modern shops - in Vietnam, it is barely into double digits, which is very low compared to, say, Thailand.

"We have a very nice road ahead of us to develop the business and our footprint here," he says.

Central is considered a successful case study but making Vietnam profitable has required flexibility and patience. Langlet's business outlook for the rest of this decade is very different to how things were when the Thais arrived in 2012 with department stores and franchised fashion brands. Most of the fashion shops have closed and there are now only two department stores. "We might come back to fashion in a couple of years," he says.

Many businesses mistimed their market entry - and not just foreigners. Tran Thai Hoai Anh has been a trailblazer for European fashion retail in Vietnam. Starting in 2007, she opened a string of monobrand shops for the likes of Chloé, Loewe and Balenciaga, later replacing them with a multibrand shops and concept store Runway, which continues to grow. "It was too early for lesser-known labels that weren't at the level of Gucci, Dior, Hermès or Louis Vuitton," she says. These days, there is plenty of money in Ho Chi Minh City and the lure of Vietnam is likely to increase next year when various free-trade deals come into effect, making it easier for overseas brands to open retail outlets.

The most striking examples of Ho Chi Minh City’s economic rise can be found in property. Englishman Philip Cluer is the coo of developer Refico. He calls the current market “commercially buoyant” and for good reason. Floorspace at The Nexus, a Refico-developed office tower that is expected to open in District One in 2024, has been snapped up by a range of blue-chip foreign businesses that are clearly willing to pay Hong Kong-style rents for a prime spot in what is still a developing country. The residential sector is similarly frothy. The River is Refico’s recently completed residential tower in Thu Thiem, a greenfield area of District Two on the other side of the Saigon River. Only a few apartments remain on the market, despite a two-bed property costing about $500,000 (€475,000). The address is proving popular with South Korean and Japanese tenants, who receive a furnished apartment, fantastic views and use of an outdoor 50-metre pool for an average of $1,700 (€1,610) a month.

Thu Thiem is being marketed as Vietnam’s answer to Shanghai’s Pudong, the former rice field that was transformed into a vertiginous financial district opposite the Bund waterfront area. There’s certainly some geographic merit to this sales pitch, along with the towering ambition to back it up. A 333-metre-high Ole Scheeren skyscraper that will

be Ho Chi Minh City's tallest building is among the projects on the drawing board. That should excite anyone who has been to Shanghai.

The comparisons to China are apt in more ways than one. At the end of 2022 a Beijing-style anti-corruption drive took down one of the southern city's most prominent property tycoons. Debt markets froze and private property firms scrambled to shore up their finances, mothballing major developments and offloading assets. Since then, jittery officials have been too nervous to grant new approvals. The extent of the fallout took everyone by surprise, hitting adjacent industries, from mattress sellers to supermarkets. Nor were international firms spared. The Mandarin Oriental Saigon was forced to put on hold plans to open at a prime address owned by the tycoon, who is still languishing in jail.

People speak about the scandal in hushed tones, strictly off the record. One common takeaway is the importance of finding a trustworthy local partner. Ultimately, no company should invest in Vietnam believing that Hanoi is fundamentally very different from Beijing, nor should they see Vietnam as a bastion of democracy, free speech or human rights. The one-party system and five-year plans deliver the same pros and cons: stability and predictability but also opaque decision-making, corruption and lack of accountability. Hanoi's approach to the coronavirus pandemic was straight out of Shanghai's playbook: workers lived in their factories for months, supermarkets were shuttered and the army delivered groceries. With the poor health of Vietnam's most powerful leader a matter of public record, another major political earthquake is expected.

The effect of placing Ho Chi Minh City on ice for a year has been to create an even bigger property-development pipeline. One executive referred to 2023 as the year of paperwork, implying that when the political frost eventually thaws, companies will be ready to get going.

Some cranes and construction vehicles are already moving on the skyline but the biggest ribbon-cutting will arguably happen underground. A Japanese-funded metro is finally ready to begin operating, six years behind schedule. Though one line won't change the daily commute for everyone, the new public transport infrastructure is a milestone. Shanghai reached this point in the 1990s and Bangkok followed at the end of that decade.

In this respect, Vietnam's largest city is trailing behind its peers by at least 20 years. "What Thailand has now, Vietnam will need: the basics of any developed country," says Hoa

Sen's Tammy Le. According to the World Bank and imf, the country's economy will grow by about 5 or 6 per cent a year in the near term but those numbers are likely to be revised up as Ho Chi Minh City gets back to business. The next decade will bring more luxury apartments and modern shopping centres, as well as a prestigious design school, arenas and a proper conference centre. The longest highway in southern Vietnam will open and a huge international airport will replace the poky Tan Son Nhat – a frequent source of frustration for arrivals, who have to endure its tiresome queues. All of that construction should mean bigger commercial opportunities, a far better lifestyle and plenty more mayhem.

Art for the people (Text B – Berlin, full length)

Kimberly Bradley reporting from Berlin: Cancel culture and collective hand-wringing has made the art world a rather serious place to work. Luckily the curator of Haus der Kulturen der Welt in Berlin is offering a novel way to see things – with a little levity, music and some fun.

On workdays, Bonaventure Soh Bejeng Ndikung, the new director and chief curator of Haus der Kulturen der Welt, cycles from his home in Neukölln to the office in Berlin's Tiergarten park. "Every time I cycle down Karl Marx Allee, I cross different geographies," says the Cameroon-born curator of his commute. "You can see the people and hear the languages change when you cross. This institution must belong to these people," he says, turning his attention back to the museum he's in charge of.

Since taking up his post in January 2023, Ndikung and the team have made huge strides to bridge the gap between the German capital's sometimes high-minded art institutions and the tastes and desires of the 170-odd nationalities living here. Instead of just presenting art and ideas to the Berlin public, the Haus (known to Berliners as "HKW") has created a dialogue where exhibitions, performances and events try to properly connect people with the far-flung topics it touches. "The idea was to create an institution that reflects the different kinds of people who live here," he says in his trademark baritone.

When O Quilombismo, a 68-artist exhibition, opened in spring 2023, the mission became a little clearer and offered a taste of Ndikung's tenure to come. At the three-day open-house extravaganza, art lovers thronged HKW, where art adorned exhibition spaces as well as corridors, the atrium and even the building's auditorium. Despite the serious subject matter ("quilombos" are self-governed communities founded by enslaved people in Brazil) it was the sense of levity and excitement - rather than sombre soul-searching - that was inescapable. Visitors of all ages hung out in a flag-festooned outdoor pavilion where a "kids' disco" allowed youngsters to have fun while their parents took in the art. Sculptures, flags and installations by the likes of Ghanaian art star Ibrahim Mahama dotted the grounds and added colour and vivacity to proceedings.

On the flat parts of a sweeping roof (Berliners have long referred to the oddly. shaped building as "the pregnant oyster"), food stands served Thai, Cameroonian, Nigerian and other specialities to the sounds of live bands from across Africa and beyond. Above it all,

three flags flew in black, red and green stripes, each emblazoned with a letter: together they read DDR, an acronym standing for "decarbonise, decolonise, rehabilitate": so far so serious? Perhaps, but this pointedly also stands for "Deutsche Demokratische Republik", the name of the former East Germany. Fluttering close to the Federal German Chancellery and parliament buildings, the flags were artist Olu Oguibe's poignant nudge to audiences to radically rethink the notion of Germany's own divisions and all it's been through.

The building was erected in the 1950s by the Americans, who later donated it to the West German government. In 1989 it became a cultural centre. In recent years the space attracted a cerebral set including exhibitions on the CIA's involvement in art and conferences on art-world topics such as the Anthropocene. Ndikung's tenure, however, meant broadening that definition of art. "Berlin is one of the most unique cities in the world," says senior curator Cosmin Costinas, who moved to Berlin from Hong Kong to work with Ndikung. "Because (the layers of migration are) so recent, the connections between people and their countries of origin are deeper and more alive."

HKW's agenda is in stark contrast to conventional art-historical institutions - especially the sometimes-criticised Humboldt Forum, another Berlin institution dedicated to non-European objects and art that opened in the summer of 2021. Humboldt Forum, like many museums today, is in flux, paralysed by questions of provenance, power and some darker parts of Germany's history. It holds the state ethnological collections, including the Benin bronzes, which Germany has begun to return to Nigeria. While the HKW has its own history, the curators and staff aren't looking back; they're trying to start a new chapter including renaming all the public spaces after women who worked, often invisibly, to improve lives. One of the ponds in front of the building is now named after Chilean folklorist Violeta Parra and the HKW offices are named after Senegalese women's rights campaigner Awa Thiam, to name just two.

Other changes were internal: instead of hiring a large staff on the art world's precarious year-by-year contracts, Ndikung - Berlin's first non-white museum director and a biotechnologist by training - offered longer contracts and fuller benefits but to fewer team members, many of whom hail from Africa and South America. East Germany-born Henriette Gallus is deputy director, a unique position in a system that still generates star museum directors ("No one can do this alone," she says). After a long research phase beginning when Nikung applied for the job in 2021 (a big decision after founding and operating Savvy Contemporary, a wildly successful project space, for more than a

decade), the two restructured the HKW during a five-month closure. Teams now work across artistic disciplines, their members have more agency and the opportunity to combine family and work is not just a perk but a priority.

Forthcoming events will tackle the idea of the "Global East", including Germany's own past. But the HKW wants to generate some intrigue, fun and curiosity rather than shutting down conversations or tying itself in knots trying to signal its own virtue. "We want the audience to understand that this is about them: about their daily life, their understanding, love, passion and tears," says Gallus. Just two weeks after HKW reopened, O Quilombismo was already the one of the most-visited exhibition the space has hosted in the past 25 years. The visitors kept coming - many more than once - and often for hours. The opening weekend's kids' disco was such a success that parents asked for more; HKW now runs it twice a month. "People feel like they're a part of it," says Gallus. "That's the magic of us with the audience. Without them, these would be empty halls."

Greek revival (Text C – Elefsina, full length)

Stella Roos reporting from Elefsina: Heavy industry - and its departure - has shaped a small but ancient Greek city. Becoming European Capital of Culture has given its artistic offering a welcome boost and shows the way ahead for other post-industrial outposts.

Every autumn the 21km stretch of beach leading northwest from Athens to the city of Elefsina hosts a set of ancient rites intriguingly dubbed the Great Mysteries of Eleusis. Initiates, sometimes thousands at a time, take part in the secretive nine-day ritual - including toasting the dead and some walking - that was once said to promise eternal happiness in the afterlife. While a visit today might not offer a ticket to a happily-ever-after place, Elefsina (formerly Eleusis) is a great example of how being nominated a European Capital of Culture can help smaller cities jostle for cultural prominence at home and abroad.

Since its ancient heyday, the hills and olive groves have been cut through by a six-lane highway dotted with petrol stations, fast-food joints, junk yards and refineries that obscure the view of the sea from the Bay of Elefsina. The road is at once one of the most sacred of antiquity walked by Plato, Socrates and several Roman emperors- and an industrial backwater that's still easily missed by holidaymakers and commuters shuttling back and forth to the Peloponnese.

MONOCLE exits the motorway on a fair Friday and finds shade in a courtyard of a disused olive-oil mill close to the waterfront. It is the setting for an exhibition called Elefsina Mon Amour: In Search of the Third Paradise. "For Athenians, Elefsina has long been terra incognita," says curator Katerina Gregos. Soon a well-heeled crowd of locals and Athenians fill the courtyard to toast the opening. At sunset they're whisked off by bus to a two-hour dance performance set against the rusting hull of a stranded ship. These are just two events that have happened as part of the city's stint as a 2023 European Capital of Culture; many here hope that this will help get this city back on its feet.

This is the fourth time that Greece has hosted a European Capital of Culture, starting in Athens in 1985. The story goes that Melina Mercouri, actress-turned-minister of culture, came up with the idea while stuck at the airport with her French counterpart Jack Lang in the early 1980s. Mercouri pitched it to the European Commission and the EU obliged by footing the bill. The blockbuster first edition included a to-hour play and shows by

German choreographer Pina Bausch, Swedish director Ingmar Bergman, jazz from Miles Davis and plenty of fireworks. In the following years, successive European cities took their turn in the limelight by hosting the cultural festival.

The definition of what makes a European Cultural Capital has shifted over time. Apart from awarding the title, the EU's support is mostly of the moral kind and funding is limited to a €1.5m Melina Mercouri Prize. Since 2000, multiple cities have been appointed each year based on formalised selection criteria (the rotation of host countries is set by the EU parliament and cities are picked through national competitions). Instead of established cultural centres such as Athens or Amsterdam, the priority has shifted to more peripheral, post-industrial cities that could use a lift: think Timisoara in Romania and Veszprém in Hungary.

Even so, many were surprised when, in 2016, Elefsina was awarded the title for 2021 (postponed to 2023 due to the coronavirus pandemic). With just 20,000 inhabitants, it's the smallest European Capital of Culture to date and, while the archaeological site at its centre is famous among classicists, even some locals were left scratching their heads at what culture would be on offer to visitors.

If you walk along Elefsina's central thoroughfares, you'll see some sweeping contrasts: on one side there's the ancient Well of Demeter, where Homeric myth puts the harvest goddess mourning her lost daughter Persephone, and on the other is a gaming parlour with street-side slot machines. The top stay is the city's sole four-star hotel and the only cultural venue before the festivities was a rickety outdoor amphitheatre. "There was no infrastructure," says Michail Marmarinos, artistic director of Eleusis2023. "It was a huge challenge." Marmarinos, one of Greece's foremost contemporary playwrights, stepped in as artistic director in 2020. He secured a postponement and herded the whole organisation into action. Marmarinos' theme became "Mysteries of Transition", a remix of the city's ancient claim to fame and a hope that a new procession might spur its cultural growth beyond its Capital of Culture tenure.

The transition that Elefsina is undergoing is a version of the story shared by many European Cultural Capitals: of reviving a city built and then abandoned by heavy industry. At the turn of the 19th century, Elefsina's shore was lined with shipyards, refineries and soap and cement factories. Immigrants from all over Greece and the Balkans arrived in

search of work. In the 1970s the factories spewed so much ash into the air that Elefsinians couldn't even hang their laundry outside. The sea was more black than blue.

"This was really a scarred landscape, in many senses of the word," says Gregos. For Elefsina Mon Amour, she invited 16 artists from nine countries to create newly commissioned pieces (a key goal of the European Capital of Culture is to put artists to work). The exhibition is spread across three dimly lit factory halls. The show's title is a reference to Hiroshima Mon Amour, a 1959 film by Alain Resnais. "Only the difference is, the catastrophe (here) did not come from nuclear war but from industry," says Gregos.

Marina Gioti spent more than three years on an artwork called "Sounding the Silent World" for which she mapped the shipwrecks in the Elefsinian gulf using sonar. The resulting abstract, amber images are mesmerising and highly political: Gioti was forbidden from publishing the names of the 12 ships she found decaying on the seafloor. The bay is still strewn with abandoned ships but the clean-up of the sea started in the 2000s and now locals happily jump in for a swim.

Artistic duo Joanna Tsakalou and Manos Flessas created “Hadal Zone”, a visual opera in five acts, which leads up to the top of an outdoor amphitheatre, where visitors are serenaded while taking in Elefsina’s industrial horizon through binoculars. The vista is memorable. Just down the coast, one of the largest oil refineries in the Balkans shoots up a flame every few seconds.

As night begins to fall, Monocle returns to the Old Oil Mill. “It looks like Manhattan,” says Yorgos Skianis as he looks out over the jumble of factory buildings. Skianis, an Elefsina local, organised the Aeschylia Festival that connected visual artists with factory spaces to exhibit their work long before the Capital of Culture crowd showed up. “We showed people that Elefsina can produce more than just pollution,” he says, drawing attention to the fact that Capitals of Culture need backing after the banners and EU funds have been and gone. He tells Monocle about growing up in the city when it wasn’t possible to access the waterfront at all. “We Elefsinians used to avoid saying where we were from. There was a stigma,” he says as the venue’s DJ strikes up and the crowd begins to move in rhythm. “They are proud,” he adds, gesturing to the people and raising his voice with the crescendo of the music. “Today nobody pretends not to be from Elefsina.”